

LIBERTY CYBER THREAT INTELLIGENCE

THE ALAMO THREAT BRIEF™

OPEN SOURCE INTELLIGENCE

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Executive decision intelligence for Texas critical infrastructure.

LIBERTY CTI OPEN SOURCE ANALYSIS

This issue of the **Alamo Threat Brief** covers the period **23–29 March 2026**. The centerpiece this week is Iran's MOIS-operated Handala network — now confirmed by the U.S. Department of Justice as a state intelligence front — and its two most consequential operations of the conflict: the **Stryker wiper attack** (the most significant Iranian cyberattack against a U.S. company since the war began) and the **breach of FBI Director Kash Patel's personal email**. Together, these two operations reveal a sophisticated, multi-track Iranian cyber doctrine that every Texas executive needs to understand — regardless of sector.

CENTERPIECE ANALYSIS

On 27 March 2026, Iran-linked hackers publicly released over 300 emails, personal photographs, and documents from FBI Director Kash Patel's personal Gmail account. The operation was claimed by Handala Hack Team — the same group that three weeks earlier executed a destructive wiper attack against Stryker, a Fortune 300 medical technology company, wiping data from more than **200,000 devices across 79 countries**.

These two operations are not isolated incidents. They are sequential moves in a deliberate, multi-track operational campaign. The U.S. Department of Justice has formally confirmed what intelligence researchers already assessed: **Handala is not a hacktivist collective — it is an operational persona run by Iran's Ministry of Intelligence and Security (MOIS)**, assessed by Palo Alto Networks to be part of the threat cluster known as Void Manticore. The "hacktivist" framing is deliberate cover that gives Tehran plausible deniability while achieving strategic signaling.

For Texas executives: the lesson is not that the FBI director got hacked. The lesson is that the same actor who wiped a \$25 billion medical technology company's global network — using nothing more sophisticated than **compromised Microsoft Intune credentials** — is now operating freely against U.S. targets, has reconstituted its infrastructure within hours of a federal takedown, and has explicitly declared it will continue. **Any Texas organization using Microsoft 365 device management at enterprise scale is operating in the same risk environment as Stryker.**

Section I

Key Judgments

KJ-1

Liberty CTI assesses with **HIGH CONFIDENCE** that Handala — a confirmed MOIS-operated persona — **almost certainly** will continue offensive cyber operations against U.S. targets regardless of U.S. government domain seizures or legal actions. DomainTools confirmed Handala reconstituted new operational domains within hours of the DOJ's March 19 seizure. The group explicitly stated: *"We decided to respond to their seizure."* Takedowns are attrition, not termination.

HIGH CONFIDENCE

KJ-2

The Stryker attack methodology — credential compromise via infostealer malware, privilege escalation in Microsoft Active Directory, mass device wipe via Microsoft Intune — **very likely** represents a replicable playbook now available to multiple MOIS-affiliated actors. The FBI has published technical malware indicators. Texas healthcare organizations, energy sector operators, and defense contractors using Microsoft 365 with Intune-based device management face **elevated and immediate exposure** to this attack pattern.

HIGH CONFIDENCE

KJ-3

The Patel Gmail breach reveals a persistent Iranian long-cycle collection operation against U.S. national security officials that **almost certainly** predates the current conflict. NBC News reporting confirms the emails were organized into folders last modified in May 2025 — nine months before the current war. The metadata indicates this was a pre-staged operation held in reserve and deployed for maximum psychological and political effect at a moment of conflict escalation.

HIGH CONFIDENCE

KJ-4

Handala's operational pattern — targeting life-critical sectors (healthcare, water, energy), using supply-chain footholds to reach downstream victims, and following attacks with amplified propaganda — **likely** signals that Texas Medical Center ecosystem vendors and mid-tier Texas healthcare suppliers are **higher-probability targets** than large hospital networks directly. Palo Alto's Unit 42 explicitly documented Handala's preference for supply-chain access to reach downstream victims.

MODERATE CONFIDENCE

KJ-5

Iran's cyber doctrine in the current conflict is executing **almost certainly** along three simultaneous tracks: **Track 1** — destructive state operations (Stryker wiper) for maximum real-world disruption; **Track 2** — hack-and-leak influence operations (Patel Gmail) for psychological effect and political embarrassment; **Track 3** — ongoing ICS/OT reconnaissance targeting energy and critical infrastructure for future disruptive positioning. Texas faces exposure across all three tracks.

HIGH CONFIDENCE

Section II

Handala / MOIS: Three-Track Operational Doctrine

Understanding Handala requires setting aside the hacktivist framing entirely. This is a Ministry of Intelligence and Security operation. Its "hacktivist" persona serves a specific function: it allows Iran to conduct aggressive cyber operations while maintaining deniability at the state level, creates a psychological effect that amplifies actual damage through propaganda, and generates a public information channel to

threaten, embarrass, and demoralize adversaries.

Target: Stryker (Fortune 300, March 11)

Method: Infostealer credential theft + Active Directory privilege escalation + Microsoft Intune mass device wipe

Scale: 200,000+ devices across 79 countries. Order processing, manufacturing, and shipping disrupted globally.

Texas relevance: Any large Texas enterprise using Intune-based device management is operating on the same attack surface.

Target: FBI Director Kash Patel personal Gmail (March 27)

Method: Long-cycle credential collection (pre-staged May 2025), released for maximum political impact during wartime

Effect: Embarrassment of senior U.S. law enforcement; signal to other officials they are vulnerable; public proof of capability

Texas relevance: Executive personal email hygiene is an operational security imperative, not just a personal matter.

Targets: Energy infrastructure, water systems, PLCs with Israeli-made or U.S.-affiliated components

Method: Default credential attacks on internet-exposed ICS devices; CyberAv3ngers ladder logic deployment

Effect: Pre-positioned access for potential future disruptive execution

Texas relevance: Gulf Coast LNG terminals, ERCOT-connected utilities, petrochemical SCADA systems — directly in scope.

"Groups like Handala blur the line between hacktivism and state operations, giving governments plausible deniability while still achieving strategic signaling. These campaigns are rarely isolated — they are part of a broader pressure strategy designed to create disruption across multiple industries that support national stability."

— Palo Alto Networks Unit 42, March 2026

The Stryker Attack — What Texas Executives Must Understand

The Stryker attack is the most instructive operational case study of the current conflict for Texas business leaders. Stryker is a \$25 billion Fortune 300 company with a global security organization, 56,000 employees, and DoD/VA contracts. It was brought to its knees not by sophisticated zero-day exploitation, but by a chain of failures that are present in the overwhelming majority of enterprise Microsoft 365 environments.

CRITICAL INTELLIGENCE WARNING

The attack chain: **Stage 1** — Infostealer malware (masquerading as legitimate apps including Pictory, KeePass, and Telegram) delivered credential theft capability. **Stage 2** — Persistent implant established. **Stage 3** — Attackers used stolen credentials to access Stryker's Microsoft Active Directory and gained administrative rights to Microsoft Intune, the company's enterprise device management platform. **Stage 4** — Remote wipe command issued across all enrolled devices globally. The FBI has published malware indicators for all stages.

Stryker initially stated there was "no indication of ransomware or malware." Further investigation by Palo Alto Networks Unit 42 later identified that a malicious file was used to run commands and hide attacker activity within the environment. This is a critical lesson: **absence of evidence is not evidence of absence**

when a sophisticated MOIS-affiliated actor has been operating inside your environment.

The recovery impact was concrete. Stryker confirmed the attack disrupted order processing, manufacturing, and shipments globally. An SEC 8-K filing confirmed disruptions were expected to continue. Employees were told to remove Microsoft Intune from personal devices immediately — a signal of how far the compromise extended into personal device ecosystems under bring-your-own-device policies.

The Patel Breach — The Strategic Intelligence Reading

The operational value of the Patel breach to Iran is minimal. The emails are a decade old, contain no government information, and the FBI confirmed they involve no classified material. This is not an intelligence coup. It is a psychological operation executed with precision.

Three analytical observations matter for Texas executives:

1. Pre-staged collection. The email files were organized into folders with metadata last modified in May 2025 — nine months before the current war began. Iran had this material in hand, held it, and released it at the most politically damaging moment: the week that the DOJ announced it had taken down Handala's websites. The message was explicit: "We decided to respond to their seizure." This is disciplined operational tradecraft, not reactive hacktivism.

2. The whack-a-mole problem is real. Check Point's Gil Messing characterized the DOJ domain seizures as striking Handala "where it matters" — but also acknowledged "in the past they've managed to bypass takedown by bringing up new channels instead." DomainTools confirmed new Handala domains were active within hours of the March 19 seizures. The group's infrastructure is distributed, redundant, and fast to reconstitute. Federal enforcement actions are necessary but insufficient to neutralize the threat.

3. This is a signal to every U.S. executive. Check Point's assessment was direct: the hack-and-leak against Patel was designed to make senior officials "feel vulnerable." For Texas C-suite and board-level executives — who routinely handle sensitive business correspondence via personal email, personal phones, and personal cloud storage — this is not an abstract warning. Personal digital hygiene is now a material business risk.

ASSESSMENT

Liberty CTI assesses with HIGH CONFIDENCE that Handala's operational tempo will very likely remain elevated through at least the next 60 days, conditioned on the continuation of the Iran-U.S.-Israel military conflict. The group's rapid infrastructure reconstitution following the DOJ March 19 seizure, its pre-staged operational reserve (evidenced by the Patel email metadata), and its explicit declaratory statements confirm an organization operating with strategic patience and tactical resilience. The \$10M State Department reward and continued law enforcement pressure are likely to drive Handala toward higher-impact operations designed to demonstrate survivability. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Section III

Texas Sector Implications — This Week

âš¡ Energy

CRITICAL

The Stryker attack is a direct preview of what a Handala operation against a Texas energy company looks like. Enterprise Microsoft 365 environments with Intune device management are the attack surface. Gulf Coast LNG operators, Permian Basin producers, and ERCOT-connected utilities should immediately audit

Intune administrative access, enforce phishing-resistant MFA on all M365 admin accounts, and review BYOD policies. ICS/OT Track 3 operations continue in parallel — energy infrastructure faces simultaneous exposure to both enterprise IT wiper attacks and industrial control system reconnaissance.

â™¥ Healthcare

CRITICAL

The Texas Medical Center is the largest medical complex in the world and relies on a dense ecosystem of medical technology vendors — many of whom are Stryker competitors or customers with similar Microsoft 365 configurations. Handala explicitly targeted Stryker because of its Israeli acquisition (OrthoSpace, 2019) and DoD/VA contracts. TMC-affiliated vendors with Israeli technology partnerships, Israeli-made equipment in their product lines, or federal healthcare contracts are now priority-assessed targets. The Stryker wiper malware indicators published by the FBI should be immediately operationalized by TMC security operations teams.

ðŸ▪ Finance

HIGH

The Patel breach is the most directly relevant development for Texas financial sector executives this week. The operational lesson — that personal Gmail accounts of senior officials can be compromised and held for strategic release — applies directly to bank executives, energy company CFOs, and defense contractor leadership whose personal communications may be of intelligence value to MOIS. USAA, Frost Bank, and DFW-based financial institutions should treat personal executive email hygiene as a board-level risk topic, not an individual IT matter.

ðŸ›j Defense

HIGH

San Antonio's Tier 2/3 defense contractor ecosystem — Port San Antonio tenants, JBSA supply chain, 16th Air Force support vendors — faces compounded risk this week. Handala has specifically targeted organizations with Israeli technology partnerships and U.S. government contracts — both characteristics common across the San Antonio defense industrial base. Meanwhile, China's Volt Typhoon continues its steady-state collection against defense networks. The Iran conflict is providing both MOIS and PRC MSS with simultaneous collection opportunities while U.S. security operations attention is divided.

Section IV

Priority Intelligence Requirement Responses

PIR-4

IRANIAN CYBER ACTIVITY FOLLOWING REGIONAL MILITARY ESCALATION

Response — Updated: Handala's three-track doctrine is now confirmed at operational scale. Track 1 (Stryker wiper, March 11) produced the most significant destructive cyberattack against a U.S. company in the current conflict. Track 2 (Patel Gmail, March 27) demonstrates pre-staged influence operations executed with strategic timing. Track 3 (ICS reconnaissance via CyberAv3ngers) continues at baseline. The DOJ's March 19 confirmation that Handala is a MOIS-operated persona — not an independent hacktivist group — eliminates attribution ambiguity. Iran is directly responsible for all three operational tracks. **HIGH**

CONFIDENCE

PIR-1

GEOPOLITICAL TRIGGERS FOR ADVERSARY CYBER RETALIATION AGAINST U.S. INFRASTRUCTURE

Response: The Stryker and Patel operations reveal that Iran is now retaliating for *cyber enforcement actions* as well as kinetic strikes. The Patel breach was explicitly framed as retaliation for the DOJ's domain seizures of Handala's infrastructure on March 19. This is a significant analytical update: **the trigger set for Iranian cyber retaliation now includes U.S. law enforcement actions against Iranian cyber infrastructure**, not only military strikes. Texas organizations adjacent to or supportive of U.S. government cybersecurity enforcement (including CISA, FBI, and DOJ partner organizations) should assess their own exposure accordingly. **MODERATE CONFIDENCE**

PIR-5

TEXAS SECTOR EXPOSURE TO GEOPOLITICAL CYBER PRESSURE

Response: The Stryker attack methodology directly implicates the Texas Medical Center vendor ecosystem. Stryker is a medical device company with DoD contracts and an Israeli acquisition — a target profile shared by multiple TMC suppliers and medical technology vendors operating in Texas. The attack required no zero-day capability: **compromised Microsoft enterprise credentials are sufficient to execute a global wiper attack**. Texas organizations at most risk this week: healthcare technology vendors with Israeli partnerships or federal contracts; any enterprise operating Microsoft 365 with Intune device management and limited MFA enforcement on admin accounts. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Section V

Strategic Forecast — 30 / 60 / 90-Day Outlook

30 DAYS

APR 2026

Most Likely:

Handala continues operations. The \$10M State Department reward and continued federal pressure likely

motivates a high-profile demonstrative strike intended to prove operational continuity. Healthcare or defense sector targets are assessed as most probable, given Handala's pattern of targeting organizations with Israeli technology connections and U.S. federal contracts — both attributes common in Texas. Microsoft 365 wiper-style attacks against a Texas-based organization are now a credible near-term scenario, not a theoretical one.

Watch for:

FBI flash alerts or CISA advisories specifically referencing Intune/Active Directory compromise by MOIS-affiliated actors — would signal active exploitation in the U.S. domestic environment beyond Stryker.

MODERATE CONFIDENCE

60 DAYS

MAY 2026

Most Likely:

Iran's operational posture bifurcates based on conflict trajectory. If a ceasefire framework emerges, Handala's operational tempo

likely

decreases but does not cease — pre-staged collection continues and may be deployed for post-conflict political leverage. If the conflict continues: Track 1 wiper operations against additional U.S. critical sector organizations are

likely

; Track 3 ICS operations move closer to disruptive execution in energy sector targets. Texas Gulf Coast energy infrastructure remains the highest-consequence potential target.

Key uncertainty:

Iran's internal leadership consolidation following Khamenei's death may produce a period of operational autonomy for MOIS units outside of Tehran — potentially leading to less coordinated but more frequent attacks.

LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE

90 DAYS

JUN 2026

Core Assessment:

The Stryker attack has permanently altered the risk calculus for enterprise Microsoft 365 environments in the United States. This attack methodology — credential theft, Intune abuse, mass device wipe — is now a documented, proven, and replicable playbook. It will be adopted by criminal ransomware groups, other nation-state actors, and MOIS-affiliated cells operating outside Iran. Texas organizations that respond to Stryker the way many responded to SolarWinds — by watching and waiting — will face this threat vector from a position of unchanged exposure.

Liberty CTI assessment:

The organizations that act in the next 30–60 days — auditing Intune admin access, enforcing phishing-resistant MFA, reviewing BYOD policies, and implementing executive personal device security programs — will be materially better positioned than those that treat the Stryker attack as someone else's problem.

HIGH CONFIDENCE

Section VI

Source Citations — In Alignment with National Security-Grade Source Validation Practices

All sources are open-source. Liberty CTI does not use or disclose non-public or classified information.

SOURCE REFERENCE CITATIONS — OPEN SOURCE INTELLIGENCE BASIS — ATB-2026-3 — IN ALIGNMENT WITH NATIONAL SECURITY-GRADE SOURCE VALIDATION PRACTICES

ASSESSMENT

This brief was produced using Liberty CTI's Torch Fusion Cycle. **WHAT:** Iran's MOIS-operated Handala network executed a destructive wiper attack against Stryker and a pre-staged hack-and-leak operation against the FBI Director. **WHO:** Handala / Void Manticore — confirmed MOIS persona, not an independent hacktivist group. **WHY:** Kinetic retaliation for U.S.-Israeli strikes on Iran; counter-retaliation for DOJ domain seizures; strategic signaling of cyber capability to U.S. audiences. **WHAT COMES NEXT:** Continued operations at elevated tempo; Stryker attack methodology now a replicable playbook; Texas healthcare and energy sectors face direct exposure. All key judgments carry explicit confidence levels in alignment with national security-grade analytical practices.

For tailored executive briefings or advisory retainer inquiries: intel@libertycti.com · libertycti.com

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